

different from those that existed 100 years earlier. We printed out eight-page newsletters on white paper. They were then folded by a mechanical folder, inserted in an envelope by a mechanical inserter, taken to the post office, and hand delivered all across the nation. It was a long, expensive process.

When the Internet came along, we knew that the industry was going to be rocked by change. But we didn't know how.

"You'll be out of business within three years," said one of our young associates. "Because now people can get all the investment information they want, for free, on the Internet."

The smart money was probably betting against us. Entrepreneurs were rushing to the Internet to put up web sites. The new medium was so attractive that it attracted not just entrepreneurs with vision but investors with money.

The combination was potent. In theory, the idea was to get there first and stake out a claim. It didn't matter that you didn't really know how you were going to make money. The race was on. And you could win it by getting more eyeballs to your web site than anyone else. And that you could do, it was widely believed, by spending a lot of money on graphics, content, celebrities, and other attractions.

Obviously, the doomsayers were wrong—at least about our business. Otherwise, we wouldn't be writing a book on family wealth. We'd be writing a book on family poverty, instead.

We are, after all, the "alternative" press. And the Internet allowed us to do what we do best: offer alternative ideas, information, and recommendations, without the huge expense of printing and postage. Our business boomed.

But there are several lessons about wealth building to be learned from this episode. First, the new medium was the place to be. There was no use ignoring it. The Internet reached the "tipping point" in the mid-1990s; after that, if you were an entrepreneur, it, and not the traditional paper-based medium, was the place to be.

Newspapers were hit hard. They lost their classified advertising revenue to Internet sites such as Craigslist. Then the ink-stained printers saw their revenues drop. The Postal Service, which had already lost much of its business to Federal Express and UPS, was hit with more bad news. In 2010,